

Leonard Yang Liu

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Education

- 2022–2027 **Ph.D. in Management**, University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business
(Major: Accounting; Minor: Economics)
- 2017–2020 **M.S. in Management**, Peking University, HSBC Business School
- 2012–2016 **B.S. in Accounting**, Huazhong University of Science and Technology

Research Interests

New Technology in Accounting; Financial Intermediaries; Capital Markets; Financial Information Processing; Behavioral Finance

Working Papers

[1] “Synthesizing the Consensus: Generative AI, LLM Visibility, and the Smart Integration of Multi-Provider Consensus Forecasts”

Job Market Paper (Solo-authored)

- *Dissertation committee:* Musa Subasi (chair), Michael Kimbrough (co-chair), Rebecca Hann, Nick Seybert, Jingyi Qian, Erkut Ozbay (Dean’s representative)
- *Presented at:* University of Maryland

Abstract: This paper studies how generative AI (GenAI) tools facilitate financial information processing in the setting of the market’s integration and use of multi-provider analyst consensus forecasts. Using S&P 1500 firm-quarters over 2021–2025 covering all five major forecast data providers (FDPs), I first document a wider, more selective use of consensus after ChatGPT: prices respond more to more-accurate providers and reweight from I/B/E/S where it loses relative accuracy. I then construct an accuracy-weighted consensus, and announcement returns load on it increasingly over two heuristics: I/B/E/S and the equal-weighted average across the five FDPs. This shift strengthens with GenAI’s retrieval capability and concentrates where providers disagree most, especially where that disagreement most likely reflects methodological differences across FDPs. Measuring the visibility of each firm’s consensus forecasts to GenAI tools using the GPT-4o model, I find the synthesis benefit concentrates in high-visibility firms. The results show how GenAI powers investors’ processing of multi-provider consensus.

[2] “AI-Powered Analysts” with Michael Kimbrough and Musa Subasi

- *Status:* R&R at *The Accounting Review*
- *Honors:* Best Paper Award in Fintech, SFA 2024
- *Presented at:* University of Maryland; SFA Annual Conference

Abstract: We examine how brokerage-level adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) influences analysts’ information production. We observe substantial heterogeneity in AI adoption across brokerages, driven by factors including peer influence, organizational resources, and market pressure from institutional investors. Importantly, we find that analysts at brokerages with greater AI integration issue significantly more accurate earnings forecasts. The information advantages from AI are more pronounced when forecasts are issued earlier in the forecasting cycle, when there is less information asymmetry among analysts, when firm

disclosures are more readable, and when analysts have less experience. We also find that AI adoption helps mitigate the adverse effects of decision fatigue and reduce analysts' heuristic forecasting. Finally, forecasts issued by AI-powered analysts are more informative to capital markets. Overall, our findings underscore the role of AI in augmenting analysts' performance by improving their information processing and forecasting accuracy.

[3] **“The Role of Generative AI in Democratizing Investment Research: Evidence from Crowdsourced Forecasts”** with Musa Subasi

- *Status:* In preparation
- *Presented at:* University of Maryland, University of Missouri[‡]

Abstract: We examine whether generative AI (GenAI) helps level the playing field between professional and non-professional forecasters. Using crowdsourced forecasts from Estimote, we find that the accuracy gap between these groups narrows significantly following the release of ChatGPT, driven primarily by improvements among non-professional contributors. Exploiting ChatGPT service outages as a quasi-natural experiment, we find that forecast accuracy declines during outages, particularly for non-professional contributors, consistent with these contributors relying on GenAI for earnings-related information processing. GenAI adoption is associated with more accurate and more independent forecasts, with the largest gains concentrated among non-professionals. Cross-sectional tests indicate that GenAI's benefits are more pronounced when disclosures are less readable but are attenuated when analyst forecast dispersion is high, suggesting that GenAI is less effective in settings with greater information asymmetry. Finally, earnings announcement returns are more strongly associated with earnings surprises derived from non-professional forecasts in the post-ChatGPT period. Overall, our evidence suggests that GenAI democratizes investment research by enhancing the financial information-processing capacity of non-professionals.

[4] **“Stepping Into the Spotlight: CFO Debuts in Conference Calls”** with Nick Seybert

- *Status:* In preparation
- *Presented at:* University of Maryland

Abstract: This paper investigates whether CFOs who debut on their first earnings conference call exhibit a tendency to stay in their “comfort zone” by emphasizing numbers and accounting jargon rather than qualitative strategic information as a means of maintaining credibility in the face of potential public scrutiny, both because CFOs have more prior experience with accounting and quantitative information than with soft information, and because such information is verifiable and objective. Analyzing a large sample of earnings call transcripts, we find that debuting CFOs exhibit a significantly greater reliance on quantitative language and accounting jargon at the expense of softer strategic disclosures. These trends decline nearly monotonically over subsequent calls. The debut effect is particularly pronounced in settings where a new CFO is expected to experience greater pressure and uncertainty: when it is the CFO's first time in the C-Suite, for higher-growth firms, and when the firm reports a loss during the first conference call. We also find that CFOs engaging in greater comfort-zone behavior are less likely to be promoted to CEO at their current firm or to be hired into a C-Suite position at another firm. Finally, comfort-zone behavior does not measurably impact market or analyst reaction to conference calls. Taken together, our results suggest that debut pressure encourages CFOs to focus on accounting and quantitative information over softer strategic information during early conference calls, and that this behavior worsens future career outcomes and does not benefit the firm with respect to investors or analysts.

([‡]Presented by coauthor)

Honors, Awards, and Fellowships

2026 Frank T. Paine Award for Academic Achievement

2025	Deloitte Foundation Scholarship Nomination
2025	Long Jiang Graduate Student Fellowship
2024	Best Paper Award in Fintech, SFA Annual Meeting
2022–2027	Robert H. Smith School of Business Doctoral Fellowship
2017–2020	Peking University First-Class Scholarship

Conference Participation & Presentation

2026	AAA Annual Meeting (Aug); University of Maryland* (Apr, May); FARS Midyear Meeting (Jan)
2025	Washington Accounting Research Symposium (May); FARS Midyear Meeting (Jan); FARS Doctoral Symposium (Jan)
2024	SFA Annual Meeting* [†] (Nov); University of Maryland* (Jan, Oct); AAA Annual Meeting (Jul); Washington Accounting Research Symposium (Jun)
2023	Washington Accounting Research Symposium (Jun); Financial Information Systems and Cybersecurity Meeting (Jan)
2022	Washington Accounting Research Symposium (Jul)

(*Presenter; [†]Discussant)

Teaching

Sep 2026	GenAI and Business Research , <i>Representative PhD Student Speaker</i> University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business
Jun–Jul 2025	Principles of Accounting I: Financial Accounting (BMGT 220), <i>Instructor</i> University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business Course evaluation 3.82/4.0; Instructor evaluation 3.89/4.0
Jan 2025	Principles of Accounting I: Financial Accounting (BMGT 220), <i>Instructor</i> University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business Course evaluation 3.77/4.0; Instructor evaluation 3.85/4.0
Sep 2025	Fundamentals of Business Research , <i>Guest Speaker</i> University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business
2018–2020	Teaching Assistant Peking University, HSBC Business School

Academic Review, Service & Membership

2024–	Ad hoc reviewer , <i>Behavioral Research in Accounting</i>
2022–	Academic conference reviewer : AAA Annual Meeting (2025), China Accounting and Finance Review Conference (2025), SFA Annual Meeting (2024), Accounting, Behavior & Organizations Research Conference (2022)
2023–	Treasurer , Association of Doctoral Students, UMD Smith

2022 – **Member**, American Accounting Association

Professional Experience

2022 – 2027 **Graduate Assistant** — University of Maryland, College Park, MD
 2020 – 2022 **Investment Manager** — CSCEC, Beijing, China
 2018 **Security Research Intern** — Haitong Securities, Shanghai, China
 2016 – 2017 **Audit Associate** — Ernst & Young, Wuhan, China

Skills

Statistics SAS, STATA, R
 Programming Python (NLP & ML), oTree, ~~TeX~~ $\text{\LaTeX}$, HTML
 Languages Mandarin Chinese (native), English (proficient)

References

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